

[DC] Immersive Journalism – The Future of the News

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ABSTRACT

One intensively discussed solution to audience disengagement in journalism is emotion-inducing immersive journalism (IJ). However, many news users state they turn away from the news due to the high emotionality. This raises the question, whether emotion-inducing IJ is what audiences want. Additionally, it is still unclear, whether IJ has positive effects on a person's citizenship performance. This project fills these gaps and focuses on the value of IJ for both individual citizens and democratic society. Thereby, we provide a nuanced view on the value of emotive technologies for political communication and news production.

Index Terms: Immersive Journalism, Virtual Reality, Audience Studies, Emotion.

1 INTRODUCTION

News journalism is a profession in turmoil. This struggle extends to the relationship between news journalists and their audience. While over-emotionalization seems to be at the center of this news journalism crisis [1], one possible solution widely discussed in is the so-called 'emotional turn' in journalism [2][3]. The growing awareness that emotionality might both be part of the problem and a potential solution to the challenges of news journalism connects to another innovation: Recently, news journalism has increasingly made use of immersive technologies such as Virtual Reality (VR). Immersive Journalism (IJ) is defined as journalism that uses emotion-inducing immersive technologies and storylines to elicit an emotional response and engage the audience [4]. By putting the audience into the center of a story and letting them experience a news story as if they were there, journalists hope to create an emotional experience – with the consequence of audience engagement and rising market shares. Emotion lies at the center of IJ [5][6]. From a normative standpoint, these findings are often interpreted in a positive light, as emotions are seen to have positive effects on connecting with the audience [2]. However, as [7] argues, the effects of this audience-centered form of journalism are discussed without taking into account what the audience itself wants. How does the audience perceive IJ, which is rooted in this emotional turn?

Therefore, the aim of this dissertation is to assess the democratic value of IJ. To achieve this, I take an audience as well as an effects perspective. The two overarching research questions are: 1) To what extent and in what form does the audience want IJ? 2) How does IJ possibly aid in fulfilling desired democratic functions, while maintaining the well-being of individuals?

2 THEORY

IJ is defined as journalism that uses emotion-inducing immersive technologies and storylines to engage the audience [4]. Three features are characteristic for IJ: 1) the level of inclusion of the technology, 2) the use of immersive narratives and 3) agency possibilities for the user.

2.1 Audience Perception of Immersive Journalism

This dissertation tries to evaluate IJ from two vantage points: the audience perspective and an effects perspective. Regarding the audience, two constructs are of interest. Firstly, the construct of worthwhileness, which is composed of seven dimensions that are clarifying, why and how the audience thinks a journalistic product is worth their while [8] [9]. Secondly, we want to investigate how specific affordances of immersive journalism have an impact on the perception of the 1) content, 2) source, and 3) interface of a journalistic piece [10] [11].

2.2 Effects of Immersive Journalism

From a democratic point of view, the question is: does the use of IJ aid the individual to fulfill the requirements that go along with citizenship? Based on [12][13][14] I focus on three possible outcome variables of viewing an immersive production: **1) civic engagement, 2) topic engagement, 3) well-being.**

At the core of democratic citizenship lies the notion of civic engagement, which is defined as "the behaviors, values, knowledge, and skills that comprise political and pro-social contributions to community and society" [15]. Studies to the effect of VR on citizens' ability to participate in political actions have focused on knowledge and pro-social behavior. Regarding knowledge, studies show VR not to have an immediate impact [16][17]; however, immersive stories are remembered better over the course of an eight-week period in comparison to text [18]. Concerning pro-social behavior, VR seems to have a positive effect [19][20].

Topic engagement is defined as the intention to follow up on or a heightened interest in the story [18], as well as involvement in the story [22][23]. Results on the impact of immersive technologies on engagement are divided. Embodying an avatar, for example, led to higher engagement than the observation of a character [18], while higher technological inclusion has no impact on engagement [23].

Following positive psychology [13], this project tests whether the practice of IJ diminishes or increases the individual's well-being. In light of negativity as reason for news avoidance [24], the investigation into the effects on well-being of IJ is crucial to understand whether IJ could be a solution to declining news audiences [2][3]. Little research of the effect of IJ on well-being beyond emotional states [6][19][25] has been conducted. It is unclear how long the effects on emotional states last, and whether the experience of IJ translates into a more substantial impact on the individual's well-being.

2.3 Thought listing experiment (analysis stage)

RQ1: *How does the audience perceive the a) content, b) source and c) interface of IJ productions in contrast to a non-immersive counterpart?* For this study, I analyze an existing experimental dataset. Specifically, the data includes four lab experiments, each comparing one of the described features of IJ to a non-immersive counterpart (inclusion, agency, immersive narrative). To analyze audience perceptions of IJ, the post-test of each experiment asked participants to list up to twelve thoughts they had during the experience using an open-ended question [26]. The thoughts are analyzed qualitatively.

2.4 3.2 Factorial Survey (design stage)

RQ2: *What is the effect of specific IJ features (inclusion, immersive narratives and agency) on the evaluation of worthwhileness of the audience?* To answer these questions, a 4 (VR vs. AR vs. immersive audio vs. video) x 2 (first vs. third person perspective) x 2 (narr. agency vs. no narr. agency) x 3 (control pace vs. control location vs. no control) x 3 (positive vs. negative vs. neutral) factorial survey will be conducted [27].

2.5 3.3 Experiment (upcoming)

The experimental study aims at understanding the impact of specific features of IJ (inclusion, immersive narratives and agency, IVs) on civic engagement, topic engagement and well-being (DVs). Additionally, the role of cognitive and affective states in mediating the relationship between IJ and possible outcomes are analyzed. RQ4: *What is the effect of specific IJ features (inclusion, immersive narratives and agency) on a) civic engagement and b) topic engagement and c) well-being?* RQ5: *How are the effects in RQ4 mediated by emotions and sense of presence?* The experiment is based on three defining features of IJ [4] as a 2 (inclusion vs. no inclusion) x 2 (immersive narrative vs. no immersive narrative) x 2 (agency possibility vs. no agency possibility) posttest-only between subject design. Two follow-up post-tests one and three weeks after stimulus exposure will be conducted.

CONCLUSIONS

Currently, the thought listing data is being analyzed qualitatively. Additionally, the factorial survey is in its final stages of design. The experiments are planned to be designed in June / July. Overall, this research project is positioned within journalism studies, political communication and technology studies. I would be most interested in discussing the results of the factorial survey and their implications. Secondly, I would like to discuss the experimental designs and receive insights regarding the proposed dependent variables and their interplay with IJ.

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